





A full-page photograph of a female trail runner in motion on a dirt path. She is wearing a red tank top, blue shorts, a grey cap, sunglasses, and a hydration vest. The background features a dramatic mountain landscape with steep slopes and distant peaks under a cloudy sky.

SECTION FOUR

How to Train



CHAPTER NINE

Programming

“Training is not the work you do. It is the effect that work has on your body.”

– Renato Canova

This is the part of the book where we get down to the business of helping you build an effective plan. Don't expect the next pages to lay out a detailed prescription. Because of the widely varying differences between athletes and the need for individuality, it is not possible to provide a one-size-fits-all training plan. If you've paid attention through the previous parts of this book, you will be able to use those general principles presented earlier while taking into consideration your own background, goals, and needs to craft your own customized plan, like a good coach would. This section of the book will explain how to implement the basic principles of training in a workable plan. Since the possible permutations of all the variables involved in creating an individual plan for all levels of athletes, for many different events with different seasonal goals, is nearly infinite, we will use example weeks and example workouts along with guidelines based on experience so that you can see how the pieces should fit together. We will not offer a cookbook recipe.

We know that one-size-fits-all training really does not fit anyone very well. We well understand that highly motivated athletes and coaches looking for ways to maximize their potential have to look beyond the ordinary. See UphillAthlete.com for more in-depth information about training methods including example weeks for the phases of different programs as well as example workouts and their proper implementation.

Previous page: Alex Earle puts in the early-morning miles above Le Tour, Chamonix, France.
Photo: Eliza Earle

Opposite: Krissy Moehl running Handies Peak, San Juan Mountains, Colorado.
Photo: Fredrik Marmsater



The classic Sellaronda Trail Run at Passo Sella, Trentino Alto Adige, Italy. Photo: Federico Modica

A well-coached but less-than-ideal training plan will give better results than the best plan in the world that is poorly administered. The successful administration of the plan is the main challenge when it comes to getting the most from your training. That is where the art of coaching takes over from the science of coaching. Why? There are few systems that we deal with on a daily basis that are as complex as the human organism. It is this amazing complexity that allows us to adapt to the stress of training in such impressive ways. It's also that complexity that makes implementing an effective plan a challenge. Which is the reason for the first 250 pages of this book.

A training plan presents training as a black-and-white affair. You either do this or you do that. However, a successful coach or successful athlete *must* operate in shades of gray on a daily basis. This gray territory is where the experience of a coach can help even the most seasoned athlete. And it is where the self-coached athlete needs to tread the most warily. That's why we spend so much time in the early pages of this book discussing how to monitor the effect that training is having on your body.

The writing of a plan, by necessity, uses a mechanistic view: Do workout A, receive benefits B. That mechanistic approach provides the guidance. But, on a

daily basis you must subtly assess and interpret your preparedness to not only do the mechanistically prescribed workout, but also to apply those same skills in evaluating the benefit from it. We want you to have those assessment tools that enable you to make changes when they are needed. That is what the first half of this book was for: teaching you these tools and imparting some guidelines to help you in your application of the plan you are about to build for yourself. Keep in mind that the plan you write is merely a suggestion and not a blueprint. It will, of necessity, have to change as you proceed. Blind adherence to *any* training plan is an almost surefire route to inferior results, if not disaster.

Coaching yourself is difficult to do effectively. Professional athletes with years of experience use coaches not because they can afford to, but because they realize the importance of an objective observer to offer guidance when they are in doubt and they know the value of having someone to bounce ideas off of.

Beginning the Plan

Keep your expectations in line with your commitment. Success at reaching your expectations breeds enthusiasm to continue, ensuring future success.

Be Realistic

Goals that are in line with both your training history and your available time is the first step. Biting off more than you can handle will at best lead to frustration and may cause you more serious issues like injury and overtraining.

Have a Goal

Any goal is better than nothing. This can range from a simple, very personal, noncompetitive goal to the goal of winning a major competition. Not having any goal is like setting sail without a destination in mind. You don't need a map (training plan) if that is what you want to do. This book and the advice we offer is intended for those who seek to maximize their personal ability and want to use this book as their map. But first they need to know where they'd like to end up.

Deciding what it is you hope to accomplish when embarking upon a training program sounds so basic that it hardly bears mentioning. Surprisingly, however, failure to clearly establish this basic goal before beginning is what most often derails the best of intentions when it comes to achieving success.

Commitment

The best plan in the world will not be worth the paper it is written on if you don't do the work. For the sports we cover in this book, this means that you will be



Enrico Deflorian executes his plan while enjoying a beautiful sunset over the Latemar Group, Italy.
Photo: Federico Modica

spending hundreds of hours, probably alone, doing fairly repetitive, unglamorous work. You need to embrace the process or the end result will elude you.

To reach your maximum potential and to achieve ambitious goals will require sacrifice on top of the commitment to train. Commitment to the goal means not only doing the training itself but giving up things that conflict with or don't support the stated goal.

Outline for Planning

Where you start in your training is going to be based on your training history. You need to honestly evaluate where you are and how much time you can commit. Use the following reality test to help guide you in your selection of both training volume and race distances.

Make a tally of the average hours per week you have spent in the last year at work/school, sleeping, eating, traveling, and with family. The remaining hours are the hours you have available to train or participate in race events. Use this as a guide and a reality check regarding the absolute upper limit of how much time you have to train.



Ideally, you'll have one or two primary events ("A" priority) as your training focus. Including less important events ("B" or "C" priority) into the planning is not a problem. It can be much more difficult if you have several "A" priority events spread over a short time. We will explain how to plan for this, but only more experienced athletes will be able to pull this off. The most effective plan has your high-priority races or events spread out far enough from one another to allow adequate time for recovery and possibly training.

Once you know your target events, write them on a calendar and code them A, B, and C priority.

- A priority events are the biggies and what you will be building the overall plan toward. For them you will need a significant taper period leading in. They may require a significant recovery period afterward because they will maximally utilize whatever capacity you can bring to the starting line. If you have more than one of these in any training cycle, it will be important to have a base-building period between them that is at least several weeks long.
- B priority events are used as tune-ups and tests leading into the A event. If planned correctly and if your work capacity is high enough, these will

not be major disturbances to the training plan. These might be shorter or less-demanding events where you can test fitness, strategy, equipment, feeding, tactics, and mental preparation. They should not be a big stretch beyond your current capacity, so they can be included into the plan with only a slight drop in training load for a few days before and after. If they are so demanding that they disrupt the overall progression in training load, you are going to have problems preparing for the A event.

- C priority events are ones that you train right through, using them as just another workout. These need not be official competitions. They may be special test events you plan into the training schedule along the way to assess fitness. They should fit into the overall progression of your training plan; you should not have to adjust your plan for them. As your plans change, these can be inserted into the training plan later without disrupting the overall progression of training.

If you don't have a big goal but want to train effectively to build a base (increase your basic work capacity), then you can essentially do only base training. This is a strategy many people can benefit from because the biggest impediment to their performing better in the mountains is probably a lack of basic work capacity. For the events targeted in this book, nothing will get you farther than improving this base. Athletes with a huge base, like Kilian, can perform well just off that base; this is what allows him to race so many times in a year.

Once you have this calendar set up and you know how many weeks you have to prepare for your goal, you can begin to lay out a very general plan. If you have never engaged in structured training, you will have to make a guess about where to start in terms of volume. No one can accurately predict your response to training without having some training history to serve as a benchmark. Those who don't have a training log to refer to will often only recall the most memorable/bigger weeks and high points and not have a very accurate idea of the average week's training load. When in doubt, start easily, with a lower volume and overall training load than you think you can manage. With the excitement of starting a new training season with new goals, there is a tendency to jump into training too aggressively. Most of us tend to overestimate our ability to handle the work. After you have completed and logged a full training cycle of at least eight months, you will be in a much better position to plan. Until then, be prepared to adjust things as you may overreach and have to take a step back and try again.

The best rule of thumb for those new to structured training is: If you are not seeing small improvements over the course of several weeks and you are using the principles presented in this book and training more than eight hours a week, then something is amiss. You may not be recovering well due to extraneous



The starting line of the summer Pierra Menta race, France. Photo: Ulysse Lefebvre

stressors in your life or the training workload is too high or the progression is too fast. You need to make adjustments to either your training load or your lifestyle, or both.

Making the Plan

In the following pages we'll lead you through the methods we use to set up a training plan. The tables in chapters 10 and 11 will act as a menu for selecting specific workouts by category to insert into the weekly plan of the various periods building toward a single event or a multievent season covering several months. Event-specific workouts are included and labeled as such where appropriate.

The approach we have taken in the rest of this section of the book is to give example weeks for each of the periods for the different events and for athletes of different levels. These weeks are accompanied by a discussion that explains how to fit them into a plan and how to progress the workouts.

A Review of Workout Categories

Aerobic Conditioning and Aerobic Capacity: Z1, Z2

This training improves your ability to do a high volume of aerobic work, which is best measured by AeT pace. It also supports high-intensity training.

- Multiple hours. Z1 and Z2, low intensity, long duration.
- Pick-ups or strides. Forty-five- to 75-minute Zones 1–2 workout with 6x15 sec to 8x30 sec accelerations up to a relaxed fast pace (spread out over the course of the workout) with a two-minute easy recovery between.
- Steady. Sustained Z2 effort for 30 to 60 minutes.

Aerobic Endurance: Z3

Increases your maximum sustainable uphill pace and extends the time you can sustain that pace.

- Continuous Z3 tempo for 20 to 40 minutes.
- Intervals. Intensity at and just below LT heart rate (Z3). Work periods of 8–15 minutes. Active recovery intervals are two to four minutes. Total work volume is 40–60 minutes.

Aerobic Power: Z4

Trains aerobic and anaerobic systems to their maximum combined capacity. Using interval style with work periods from 30 seconds to eight minutes and a work-to-rest ratio of 1:1. This is very taxing training; making up less than 10 percent of the annual volume. Intensity needs to be 90–95 percent of maximum heart rate. These are best done on an uphill.

- Recovery intervals need to be sufficient to allow you to complete each repetition at the same pace and heart rate. Total work duration of 15 to 30 minutes.
- 30/30s. See sidebar on Page 177.
- High-tempo/high-resistance intervals. One of Kílian's favorites. Two minutes of high-tempo/high heart-rate running followed by a two-minute active rest, then two minutes of long strides done on foot or skis on uphill terrain. Repeat until you feel pace and heart rate drop off.

Anaerobic Capacity: Z5

Use Hill Sprint or Hill Bounding (see page 181) for specific leg strength/power. Start this in the Base Period one time per week if your general strength is adequate. Done near your maximum intensity on the steepest hill you have available with good footing. The duration of each repetition is from 10 to 30 seconds. Full recovery (minimum of two to three minutes) between reps. Start with 6x10 sec. Add two more reps each week.

General and Max Strength

Use the Core and General Strength programs in the Transition Period twice per week. Use the max strength in the early Base Period twice per week. In the final stages of preparation, use the ME program specific for VK, long skimo, or trail run/race.



Krissy Moehl drinks a ginger soda to settle her upset stomach during an FKT attempt on the Wonderland Trail, Washington. Photo: Fredrik Marmsater

